

**Lesson 36:** “The Desert Shall Rejoice, and Blossom as the Rose” (See L36 [Study Guide](#))

**Purpose:** To help us understand how we have been blessed by the sacrifices of the early Saints in the Salt Lake Valley and to encourage us to follow their example.

**1. “Right here will stand the temple of our God.”**

Elder John A Widtsoe: “The pioneers were hungry and weary; they needed food and rest; a hostile desert looked them in the face; yet in the midst of such physical requirements they turned first to the building of temples and to the spiritual food and strength that the temples provide.” (in Conference Report, [Apr. 1943, 38](#))

†1. President Brigham Young      †2. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland (Pres. of BYU)

“It took years for the Saints to quarry, transport, and shape the granite blocks for the construction of the temple. During this time, they struggled just to survive, as they lost crops to the elements, served missions in faraway lands, and accepted calls to leave their homes and establish communities in remote areas. In spite of these many challenges, The Saints persevered, and with the Lord’s help they prevailed. The Salt Lake Temple was dedicated in 1893, 40 years after the cornerstones had been laid.” (*Lesson Manual*, 209-10)

What can we learn from the perseverance of the Saints as they built the Salt Lake Temple?

President Howard W. Hunter: “We ... emphasize the personal blessings of temple worship and the sanctity and safety that are provided within those hallowed walls. It is the house of the Lord, a place of revelation and of peace. As we attend the temple, we learn more richly and deeply the purpose of life and the significance of the atoning sacrifice of the Lord Jesus Christ. Let us make the temple, with temple worship and temple covenants and temple marriage, our ultimate earthly goal and the supreme mortal experience....”

“May you let the meaning and beauty and peace of the temple come into your everyday life more directly.” (“[Follow the Son of God](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 87-88)

**2. The Saints were obedient as they settled and colonized the Salt Lake Valley and the surrounding areas.**

†3. The First Winter in the Great Basin; Priddy Meeks

• “[The First Year in the Valley](#),” *Our Heritage*, 82-83 • “[Explorations](#),” *Our Heritage*, pages 83-84, scroll down

What Characteristics helped the Saints overcome the great difficulties they faced?  
How has the Lord blessed you in times of adversity?

†4. “[Callings to Colonize](#),” *Our Heritage*, 86-89

• D&C 58:2-4 • D&C 64:33-34 • D&C 82:10 • D&C 93:1 • D&C 130:19-21

What experiences have taught you the importance of obedience?  
What feelings do you have when you are obedient to God’s will?

**3. Missionaries made sacrifices to teach the gospel throughout the world.**

• “[Missionaries Answer the Call](#),” *Our Heritage*, pages 84-86

What can we learn from their examples?

• “[Missionary Work](#),” *Our Heritage*, pages 93-96

What can we learn from their examples?

Next Week: L37: “We Thank Thee, O God, for a Prophet”; See L37 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **President Brigham Young:** “I want to see the temple built in a manner that it will endure through the Millennium. This is not the only temple we shall build; there will be hundreds of them built and dedicated to the Lord.... And when the Millennium is over,... I want that temple still to stand as a proud monument of the faith, perseverance and industry of the Saints of God in the mountains, in the nineteenth century.” (*Discourses of Brigham Young*, sel. John A. Widtsoe [1941], 395)

†2. **President Gordon B. Hinckley: Jeffrey R. Holland (Pres. Of BYU):** “The prestigious *Scientific American* referred to [the Salt Lake Temple] as a ‘monument to Mormon perseverance.’ And so it was. Blood, toil, tears, and sweat. The best things are always worth finishing. ‘Know ye not that ye are the temple of God?’ (1 Corinthians 3:16.) Most assuredly we are. As long and laborious as the effort may seem, we must keep shaping and setting the stones that will make *our* accomplishments ‘a grand and imposing spectacle.’ We must take advantage of every opportunity to learn and grow, dream dreams and see visions, work toward their realization, wait patiently when we have no other choice, lean on our sword and rest a while, but get up and fight again.... We are laying the foundation of a great work—our own inestimable future.” (*However Long and Hard the Road* [1985], 127. Read his BYU Speech: “[However Long and Hard the Road](#).” Sister Holland speaks first and then President Holland.)

†3. **The First Winter In The Great Basin.** October 10: The last of the 1847 pioneer companies arrived in the Salt Lake Valley. There were a total of 11 arriving companies in 1847, totaling about 2,000 emigrants. Many returned to Winter Quarters leaving 1681 persons to spend the first winter in the Salt Lake.

This first winter was fairly mild, but food shortages developed. Too many had been allowed to join the second contingent which left Winter Quarters in 1847. The greens and roots of the thistle were used as well as the sego roots. There were a few deaths from eating poisonous roots, chiefly the wild parsnip. (Paraphrased from [beardall2000.com](#))

**Priddy Meeks wrote of conditions:** "My family went several months without a satisfying meal of victuals. I went sometimes a mile up Jordan to a patch of wild roses to get the berries to eat which I would eat as rapidly as a hog, stems and all. I shot hawks and crows and they ate well. I would go and search the mire holes and find cattle dead and fleece off what meat I could and eat it. We used wolf meat, which I thought was good. I made some wooden spades to dig seagoes [Sego Lily] with, but we could not supply our wants.

"We had to exert ourselves to get something to eat. I would take a grubbing-hoe and a sack and start by sunrise in the morning and go, I thought six miles before coming to where the thistle roots grew, and in time to get home I would have a bushel and sometimes more thistle roots. And we would eat them raw. I would dig until I grew faint and sit down and eat a root, and then begin again. I continued this until the roots began to fail." (*Great Basin Kingdom*, 49)

†4. **President Gordon B. Hinckley: Callings to Colonize:** "... By 1877, when Brigham Young died, more than 350 colonies had been established, and by 1900 there were almost 500...

"At general conference meetings, President Young read the names of those brethren and their families who were being called to move to outlying areas. These colonizers considered that they were being called on missions and knew that they would remain in their assigned locales until they were released. They traveled to their new areas at their own expense and with their own supplies...

"In 1862 Charles Lowell Walker received a call to settle in southern Utah. He attended a meeting for those who had been called and recorded: ‘Here I learned a principle that I shall not forget in a while. It showed to me that obedience was a great principle in heaven and on earth. Well, here I have worked for the last seven years through heat and cold, hunger and adverse circumstances, and at last have got me a home, a lot with fruit trees just beginning to bear and look pretty. Well, I must leave it and go and do the will of my Father in Heaven, who overrules all for the good of them that love and fear him. I pray God to give me strength to accomplish that which is required of me in an acceptable manner before him.’” (“[Callings to Colonize](#),” *Our Heritage*, 88)

### Recommended reading:

1. Jeffrey R. Holland (President of BYU) & Patricia T. Holland, “[However Long and Hard the Road](#),” BYU Speeches. (Sister Holland speaks first and then President Holland speaks. This is a great talk.)

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